Eleemosynary

By Lee Blessing

ECHO: **(Pg 7)** *(to audience)* ***Eleemosynary***. E-L-E-E-M-O-S-Y-N-A-R-Y. ***Eleemosynary***. It's my favorite word. Not just because I won with it, either. ***Eleemosynary***: "Of or pertaining to alms; charitable." ***Eleemosynary***. *(slowly approaches the imagined image of Dorothea laying in bed, studies her for a moment)* This is my grandmother. She had a stroke. *(opening the drapes)* She can't really talk. I can hear her, though. At least I think I can. She's seventy-five years old . . .

INTRODUCTION

That's Echo. She's amazing – a true genius and so young. Through a series of flashbacks, you'll find out more about her, her mother and her grandmother soon - a character study in triplicate. None of these women are exactly like me or you, or probably anyone we know, but you'll find bits of them in all of us. And perhaps enough information to contemplate some questions.

As women, how do we make our way through life? How do we behave as parents? How do we become who we are ***because of*** *or* ***in spite of*** *our parents? Let's rejoin Echo now in*

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ECHO: **(Pg 7-9)** *(to audience)* My grandmother believed she could fly using only a pair of homemade wings. In 1958 she made a movie of herself and her daughter, my mother, trying it out. Mom was only fifteen then. *(Echo steps into the scene as Dorothea)*

DOROTHEA: *(Speaking with force and assurance, as though to a film camera)* Hello. I am Dorothea Wesbrook. Today I am going to prove that man - or, in this case, woman - can fly without the aid of any motor of any kind, using only the simple pair of wings you see my daughter, Artemis, wearing here. *(Artie begins to edge off camera. Dorothea stops her gently without interrupting her speech)* We will try two experiments today. First, the very steep hill, and second, the wooden tower. *(turns to Artie, suddenly shouting)* Flap! For God's sake, you call that flapping?! You're being filmed!

ARTIE: *(running, flapping)* It's not working! I'm not flying!

DOROTHEA: You will! Keep trying! Concentrate!

ARTIE: *(suddenly drops the wings and speaks like a 30-year-old woman to the audience)* Never

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have a daughter. Never have a child, for that matter, but ***never*** have a daughter. She won't like you.

DOROTHEA: Keep flapping! *(Artie wails picks up her wings and begins flapping) (to camera)* **(Pg 11-13)** Well, the very steep hill seems not to have done the trick. We are moving on, therefore, to the wooden tower. *(Artie gives an "Are you serious?" look then climbs a ladder to the platform of a wooden tower while Dorothea watches)* My daughter is now, oh, about twelve feet above the ground, and . . . Let go of the railing, dear.

ARTIE: *(eyes closed)* No!

DOROTHEA: Don't be stubborn. You want to fly, don't you?

ARTIE: No!

ECHO: *(Dorothea steps out of scene to narrate as Echo)* I do . . . There's something about the Wesbrook women. We have this expectation to be extraordinary. It's a little like having a disease in the family. I fly with words. Oh, I know it sounds stupid to say, but it's true. When I was still in my crib, my grandmother was constantly shoving words and numbers in front of me. My grandmother made me love words. My mom helped, too. A little. *(steps back into the scene as Dorothea)*

DOROTHEA: Why are you so afraid to make history, Artie? *(to the camera, embarrassed)* Well. . . it appears we will not be able to complete our experiment today.

ARTIE: *(eyes closed, holding on)* Damn right. You are nuts! And now you're nuts on film! *(freezes)*

ECHO: *(Dorothea steps out of the scene to narrate as Echo)* Dorothea was one of the notable eccentrics of her time. She went on to other projects: communication with the dead, spontaneous combustion, astral projection - but she never filmed those. I can feel my grandmother in me. My mother, too - a little.

*****Scene*****

ARTIE: **(Pg 16-17)** *(to audience)* My mother made sure I had tutors from the age of four. My father worried that too much learning would hurt my hopes for marriage. But Dorothea told him a smart girl can hide what she knows, so there's still a chance for happiness. *(Dorothea.)*

DOROTHEA: *(breaks in, to audience)* Well, that's true in a way . . .

ARTIE: I'm telling this. *(turning to audience)* When I was eighteen, I got pregnant.

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DOROTHEA: It was an accident . . .

ARTIE: Mother! In fourteen years of tutoring, no one - including my mother - ever brought up the facts of life. I didn't know anything about the men 'til I went out with one of them.

DOROTHEA: *(speaking to an 18-year-old Artie)* You can't be pregnant! You can't! You're eighteen. Your college career . . .

ARTIE: What college career? I'm going to be a mother.

DOROTHEA: No. No, you're not. You don't have to be. Think about it. *(beat)*

ARTIE: What - you mean give it up for adoption?

DOROTHEA: No. That would mean your father finding out. If he knew about this, he'd have you married to someone in five minutes - and no college, either. You have to do something else.

ARTIE: What? *(beat)* That's *illegal!*

DOROTHEA: In this state. But if you go . . .

ARTIE: No! I won't do that. It's a life. *(beat)*

DOROTHEA: *(quiet, steadfast)* It's ***that*** life or yours. . . If you keep it, none of our plans, none of your potential . . . You won't be ***you*** anymore. You'll just be something a child needs.

ARTIE: I don't want to be anything more.

DOROTHEA: When a soldier in battle suddenly has to kill someone, we say that's all right. It's his life or someone else's. Well, you have a choice, too. Between living your life or someone else's. And you have to choose now.

ARTIE: *(to audience)* I waited. A little while, anyway. But finally we crossed the state line, and *(beat)* I ran away right after that. Across three state lines. I lied about my age and got a job teaching at a private school.

*****Scene***** [Many years passed. Finally, Artie called her mother]

ARTIE: **(Pg 26-28)** *(on phone)* Mom? I'm going to have a baby.

DOROTHEA: Is this your way of telling me you're married?

ARTIE: Yes . . . um, his name is Richard [and] I've finished grad school - Biochem.

DOROTHEA: That's lovely. When's the baby due?

ARTIE: Six months. *(to audience)* A week later, there she was. She bought a house on our block. I couldn't function with her around. She'd come over with some theory for making toads fly. . .

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DOROTHEA: Don't get upset, dear. I'll be down the street when you need me.

ARTIE: *(to audience)* When I had my baby, she took me to the hospital.

DOROTHEA: *(holds a baby in her arms)* A ***girl***. *(suddenly lifts the baby high above her)* This one will fly. I can feel it.

ARTIE: *(to audience) O*ne month after Echo was born, my husband died in a car accident.

ECHO: *(Dorothea steps out of scene to narrate as Echo)* When my father died, Mom didn't talk for days. That's what Grandma said, anyway. Not even to ask for food or anything. I think she really loved him.

*****Scene*****

DOROTHEA: **(Pg 14)** *(to Echo)* Are we all waked up from our nap? We're all waked up and we're three months old, and we're ready to go to *school. (tickling Echo)* Do we like school? Of course we do. Listen, Artie - she's laughing.

ARTIE: She's laughing because you're tickling her.

DOROTHEA: Well, I'm sure that's part of it. *(to Echo, playing with a toy alphabet over the crib)* Do we know this letter? That's "A." Can you say "A?" All right, how about this one? "B."

ARTIE: Mom, she's three months old. She can't talk yet. It's physiologically impossible.

DOROTHEA: *(smiling)* Echo? Try these *(dangling another string of letters)* This is "Alpha." Can you say that? And this is "Beta."

ARTIE: *(to audience)* Those baby alphabets are the same ones she had over my crib. Pink for Latin, blue for Greek.

ECHO: **(Pg 29)** *(Dorothea steps out of scene to narrate as Echo)* When I was a year old, the three of us moved back East into Grandma's house [and for a year everything was fine . . . then].

*****Scene*****

ARTIE: **(Pg 30-31)** *(beat)* I have a job offer [in] Europe.

DOROTHEA: Are you planning to take Echo with you? *(beat)*

ARTIE: I want you to keep her.

DOROTHEA: Keep her? For how long?

ARTIE: For good. I want you to keep her for good.

ECHO: **(Pg 11)** *(Dorothea steps out of scene to narrate as Echo)* Dorothea raised me from the time I

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was two.

*******Scene***** 5 years later**

ARTIE: (Pg 33-37) I called up my mother once - from Europe - when Echo was seven. I had some news. *(on the phone)* I'm coming back. I have a job opportunity in the states. I won't come visit.

DOROTHEA: Call then. You can call us anytime. Do you want Echo back? *(long beat)*

ARTIE: No. *(to audience)* Once I got settled, I started to call my mother and Echo now and then. Things went on this way for . . . six years, actually.

ECHO: [Over time] Mom suggested spelling bees. It got pretty important. She ended up calling me a lot more. At twelve, I decided to be the greatest speller in history. For life!

ARTIE: *(on the phone)* I'll find one. Just a minute. *(paging through a dictionary)* ***Metamorphosis***. You know that one, huh? Ok, how about . . . ***Syllepsis***? You know ***that***? *(Listening, nodding.)* What do you mean that's not a hard one? ***Oppugun*** is a hard one. Spell it.

ECHO: *(dutifully)* ***Oppugn***. O-P-P-U-G-N. ***Oppugn***. *(beat, to audience)* It was strange suddenly talking to her so much. *(beat)* I decided I was going to get Mom to the National Spelling Bee finals. Dorothea was coming. I wanted them both in the audience when I won it. To see that no matter what they'd done - no matter how they'd done it - they'd produced someone that was completely . . . all right. Someone with ***perspective***. P-E-R-S-P-E-C-T-I-V-E. ***Perspective***.

*******Scene******* [At the national spelling bee – The final round – Only Echo and one boy are left]

ECHO: **(Pg 37-39)** ***Glunch***. G-L-U-N-C-H. ***Glunch***. *(quickly)* I knew I was right! Glunch is such an easy word. *(beat)* What's he getting? ***Donzel****?! (suddenly outraged)* He guessed! He guessed and he got it! *(suddenly her public self)* Yes, Ma'am, I'm ready. *(listens)* ***Palinode***. P-A-L-I-N-O-D-E. ***Palinode***. *(her inner thoughts)* This can't go on forever, buddy. I'm going to crack you like an egg.

ARTIE: Echo was a little different than I thought she'd be. I mean, she was terrific and everything, but she seemed so . . . desperate.

ECHO: *(with great intensity)* Come on, miss it! You don't know it. You know you don't. *(eyes widen, in a whisper of awe)* He missed it! Dear God, please let me win! Please! Just five minutes when I'm the most famous child in America, and Mom and Dorothea see it! *(her public self again)* Excuse me, could you repeat the word?

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ARTIE: I didn't know why she was behaving that way, so competitive.

ECHO: ***Eleemosynary***. E-L-E-E-M-O-S-Y-N-A-R . . . Y. *(raises her arms in triumph)*

ARTIE: I slowly made my way to the front of the room. Echo was being mobbed, but all I could look at was the boy she'd beaten. He looked like a dead mouse.

ECHO: **(Pg 41)** *(to audience)* ***Eleemosynary***. That's the one I won with. *(beat)* I thought having both of them there would be a good thing. But it wasn't. It made me realize that I was just like them. I was just a very intelligent, vicious person. *(beat)* I called Mom a few times after the spelling bee. She was always civil, but . . . she was different. I stopped calling after a while. For two years we hardly talked at all. Then Dorothea had a stroke. So Mom came home.

*******Scene*******

ECHO: **(Pg 44-45)** What's wrong with me? Why do you keep leaving me!?

ARTIE: Echo . . . **ECHO**: ***Why!?***

ARTIE: *(tiredly)* I used to teach you wrong things. Do you know that? When you were little. Dorothea was with you every day, waggling those . . . goddamn letters and cooing. The two of you got along great. *(sighs)* So I taught you the wrong names for things. When you were starting to talk, I'd point at the floor and say, "ceiling." I'd point at the door and say, "window." And you'd smile and say ceiling and window, and I began to hope if I could just . . . retard you a little . . .

ECHO: *Retard* me?!

ARTIE: Just to be normal. I thought if you didn't seem so bright, she might get disinterested and leave us alone. But she didn't. She accused me of "intellectual child abuse." That sounds ridiculous, but it was true. I was angry at you. For picking her. For wanting her more.

ECHO: I wanted you both.

ARTIE: You couldn't have both. You got her. She was better for you than I could've been.

ECHO: Did you love me? When you left me with her? Did you?

ARTIE: Whether I loved you then or now ...

ECHO: *Did you love me? Do you?*

ARTIE: *(beat) Yes.* And no. It's always yes and no.

ECHO: **(Pg 46-47)** *(beat)* Maybe the smartest thing would be to forget you completely. And

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Grandma. After all, what did I ever get from the two of you, except a good education? You especially - what were you ever to me, except a voice on the phone now and then? Hiding behind spelling words, making excuses. Just a sound that said, "I love you, and I failed you." I hate that sound. And I will never settle for it, because no one failed me. No one ever failed me. Not Grandma and not you. I'm your daughter. That's what I choose to be. *(beat)* No matter what we've done - no matter how we've done it - we're all three of us, in our own way, completely . . . eleemosynary. E-L-E-E-M-O-S-Y-N-A-R-Y

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AWARD HISTORY

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NOTE: Check the pronunciation of all words in this cutting, especially the title and the spelling words

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